Developing Your First Video Game

From Concept to Launch

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The Core Challenge

Balancing Passion and Market Viability

The Passion Project: An idea driven purely by personal vision and creativity. This approach risks missing a potential audience or falling into a saturated market.

The Market-Driven Project: An idea born solely from market trends and data. This can feel uninspired and fail to capture player interest if it lacks a unique hook.

The Hybrid Approach: The goal is to find the intersection where your personal passions align with a market opportunity. This increases your chances of both creative fulfillment and commercial success.

Actionable Advice: Make a game you are uniquely suited to make, but with a realistic market in mind.

Phase 1: Pre-Production
From Idea to Blueprint

Market Analysis (Identify Your Niche):

- Research similar games on platforms like Steam, itch.io, or mobile app stores.
- Study sales figures, player reviews, and competitor strengths and weaknesses.
- Identify what your target audience wants that isn't currently being offered.

Concept Art (Visualize the Vision):

- Work with artists to create visual references for characters, environments, and overall art style.
- This helps solidify the game's tone and look and can be used for early pitches.

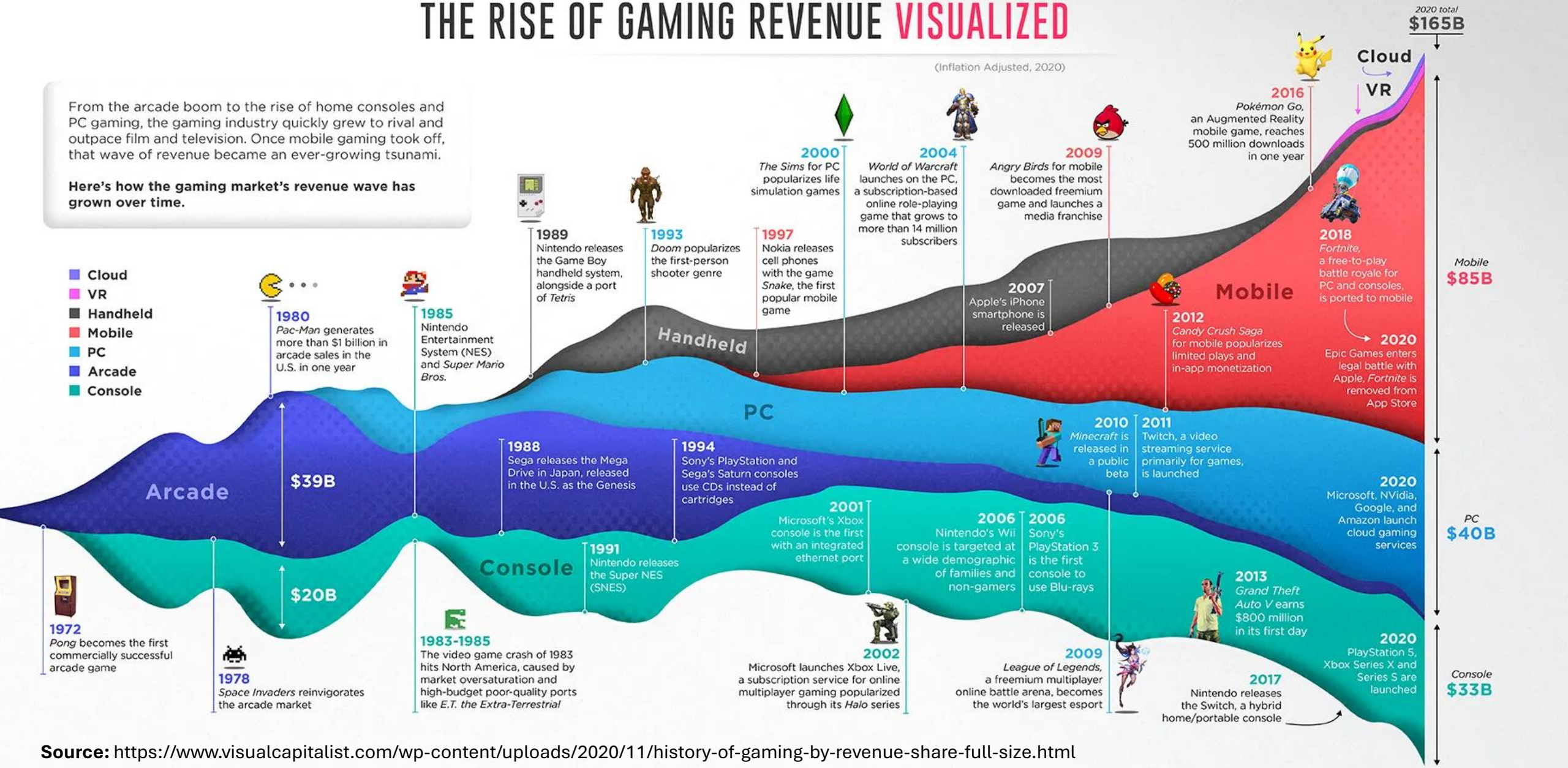
Key Deliverable: A clear project vision and initial visual direction.

THE RISE OF GAMING REVENUE VISUALIZED

(Inflation Adjusted, 2020)

From the arcade boom to the rise of home consoles and PC gaming, the gaming industry quickly grew to rival and outpace film and television. Once mobile gaming took off, that wave of revenue became an ever-growing tsunami.

Here's how the gaming market's revenue wave has grown over time.



Source: https://www.visualcapitalist.com/wp-content/uploads/2020/11/history-of-gaming-by-revenue-share-full-size.html

SOURCE Pelham Smithers
COLLABORATORS RESEARCH + WRITING Omri Wallach | DESIGN + ART DIRECTION Clayton Wadsworth

VISUAL CAPITALIST

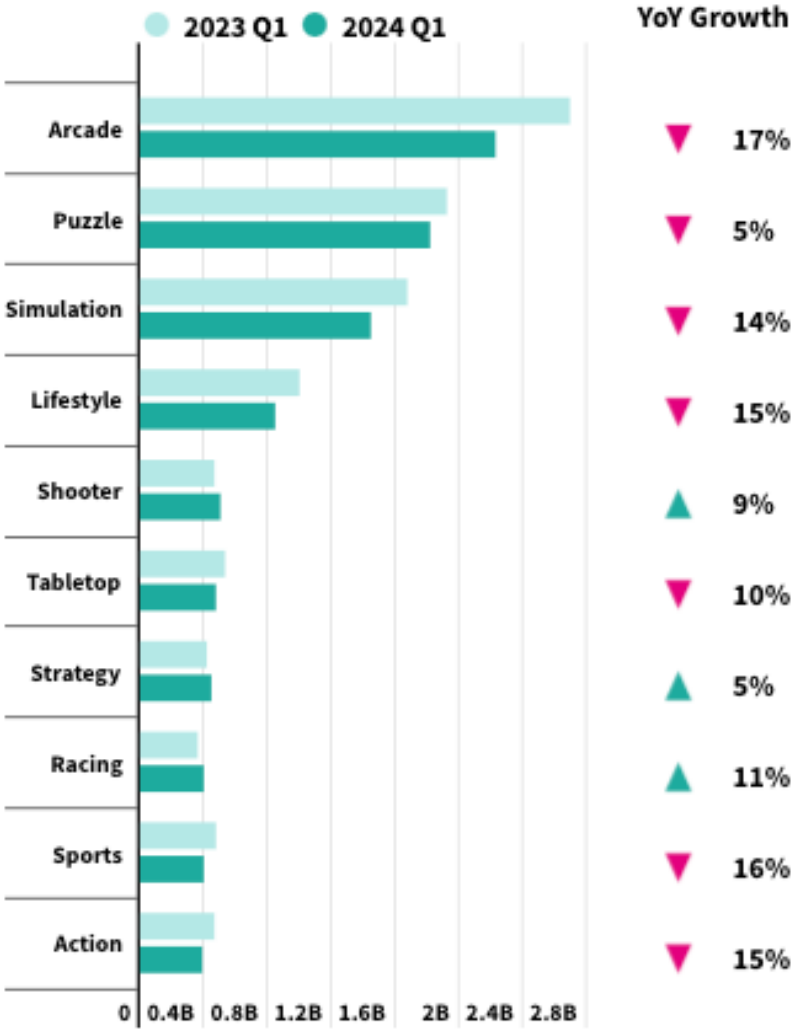
/visualcapitalist @visualcap visualcapitalist.com

Top Game Genres by Downloads in Q1 2024

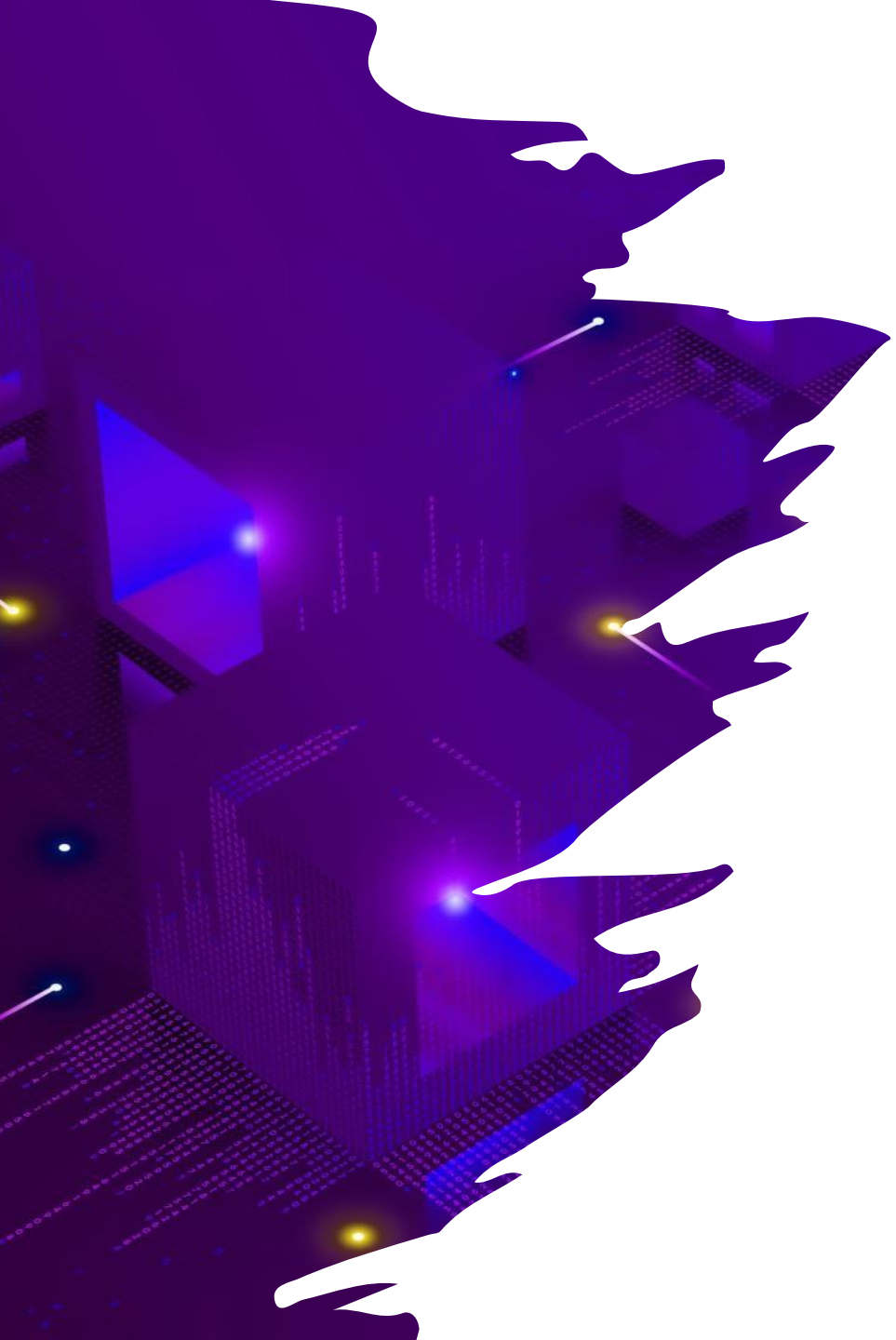
Share by Genre / Subgenre

Worldwide

Top Genres



Source: https://www.devtodev.com/resources/articles/game-market-overview-the-most-important-reports-published-in-june-2024



Phase 2: Design & Documentation

Your Project's Instruction Manual

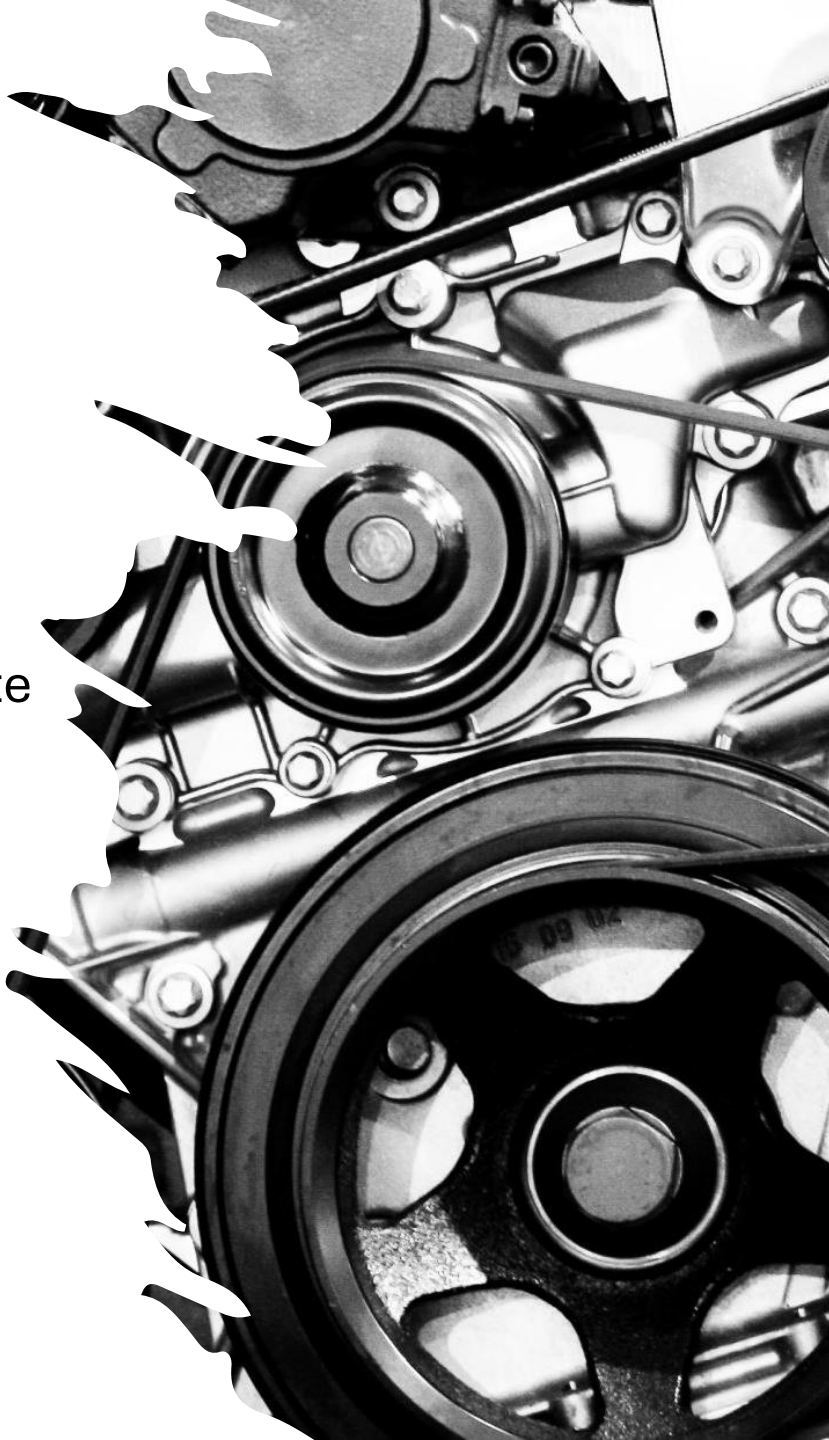
- **Game Design Document (GDD):**
  - A living blueprint detailing every aspect of the game.
  - **Content Includes:**
    - Core gameplay loop
    - Narrative and world-building
    - Character and level designs
    - User Interface (UI), Audio, and accessibility considerations
- **Technical Design Document (TDD):**
  - Outlines the technical specifications and architecture of the game.
  - Crucial for planning the "how" of development.
- **Key Deliverable:** Comprehensive GDD and TDD to guide the entire team.

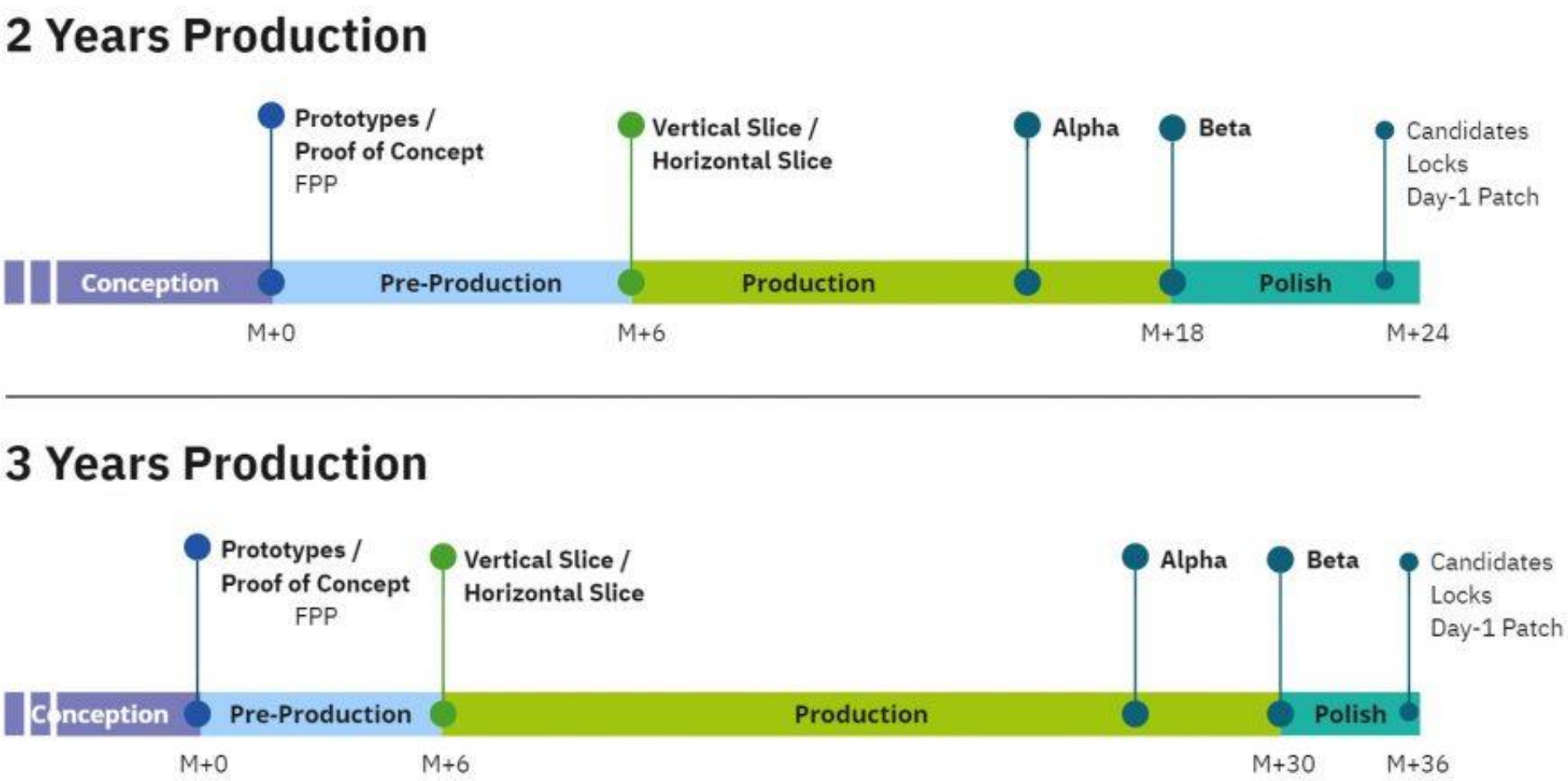
Engine Choice: Build vs. Buy

Make or License a Game Engine?

1. **Use an Existing Engine (e.g., Unity, Unreal Engine, Godot):**
   - **Pros:** Access to a vast toolset, strong community support, and rapid prototyping capabilities.
   - **Cons:** Less flexibility and potential for engine-specific limitations or licensing costs.
   - **Best for:** Most new developers and teams seeking to create a game efficiently.
2. **Build Your Own Engine:**
   - **Pros:** Full control, extreme optimization, and a deep learning experience.
   - **Cons:** Extremely time-consuming and difficult; requires a high level of expertise.
   - **Best for:** Highly unique projects or developers primarily interested in engine development.

- **Decision:** For a first project, using an existing engine is almost always the best choice.



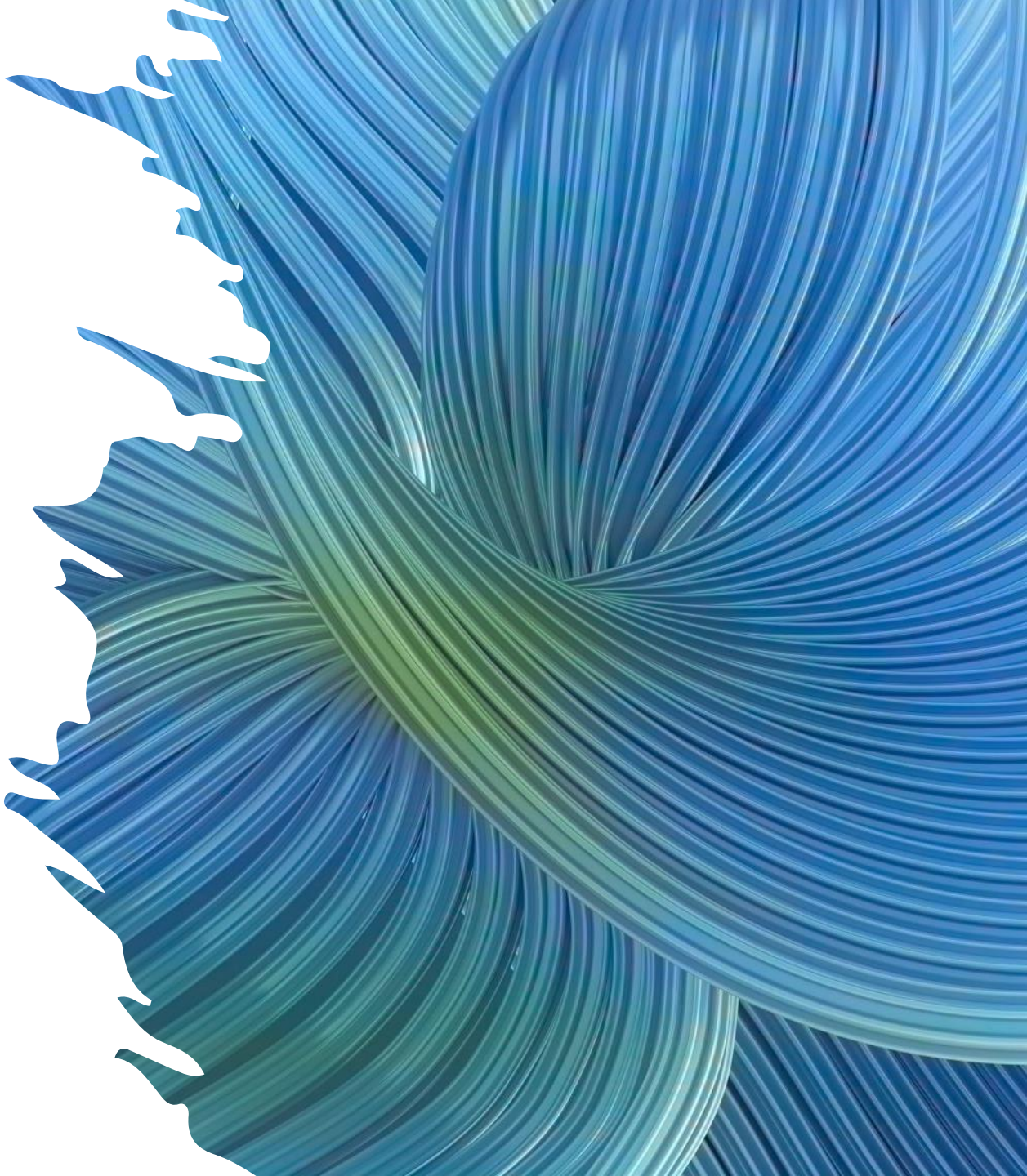


Development Cycle

Source: https://gdkeys.com/game-development-process/

Phase 3: Prototyping
Testing Core Mechanics Early

- **The Purpose:** Rapidly test the game's riskiest ideas to prove or disprove their viability.
- **What to Test:**
  - Core gameplay loop (is it fun?)
  - Key mechanics (are they intuitive?)
  - Feel and feedback (are the controls responsive?)
- **Output:** A small, playable demo focusing on a single, core loop. It may be ugly, but it must be functional.
- **Deliverable:** A "First Playable" build that proves the game concept works.



Phase 4: Production & Building

The Bulk of Development

- **Asset Creation:** Artists produce the final art assets—3D models, textures, animations, and sound effects.
- **Level Design:** Designers build out the full game world based on the GDD.
- **Core Feature Implementation:** Programmers implement all remaining features and systems.
- **Iteration and Refinement:** Continuous testing and feedback cycles refine mechanics and gameplay.
- **Key Deliverable:** A content-complete, but unpolished, version of the game.

Phase 5: Testing & Release

Polishing and Launch

- **Alpha Phase:**
  - **State:** Feature-complete, but buggy and unpolished.
  - **Testing:** Internal testing to find and fix major issues.
  - **Key Activity:** Feature freeze to lock in the game's scope.
- **Beta Phase:**
  - **State:** Feature-complete, less buggy, and more polished.
  - **Testing:** External testing by a larger group of players to find new bugs and get feedback.
- **Release Candidate (RC):**
  - **State:** A stable, "near-final" version of the game.
  - **Testing:** Final, intensive testing to ensure no critical bugs remain.
- **Release (Gold):**
  - The final, shippable version is released to the public.

The Production Process

The Game Development Pipeline

- **Version Control:** Essential for team collaboration.
  - Use systems like Git or Perforce to manage code and assets.
- **Development and Prototyping:** Build a proof-of-concept.
  - Focus on core gameplay and user experience.
  - Don't get bogged down in details early on.
- **Testing and Iteration:**
  - Get feedback early and often from your team and external testers.
  - Be prepared to adjust and refine your game based on feedback.

Launching Your Game

Going to Market

- **Develop a Marketing Strategy:** Start early to build hype.
  - Social media marketing (Twitter, Instagram).
  - Community building (Reddit, Discord).
  - Influencer outreach and press releases.
- **Choose a Platform:** Select where your game will be sold.
  - **PC:** Steam, Epic Games Store.
  - **Console:** Work with console manufacturers (e.g., Sony, Microsoft).
  - **Mobile:** Apple App Store, Google Play Store.
- **Secure a Publisher (Optional):**
  - Can help with funding, marketing, and distribution.
  - Consider the trade-offs of giving up creative control or revenue.

Post-Release: The Work Isn't Over

The Journey Continues

- **Ongoing Development:** Release is just the beginning. Plan for post-launch support with bug fixes, patches, and potentially new content.
- **Community Engagement:** Interact with your player base on social media, forums, and Discord to foster a loyal community.
- **Data Analysis:** Track player behavior and feedback to inform future updates and new projects.
- **Key Activity:** Continue iterating based on real-world player data.

Post-Release: The Work Isn't Over

Sustaining Success

- **Gather Feedback:** Monitor reviews and community forums.
- **Provide Updates:** Release bug fixes and performance patches.
- **Post-Release Content:** Plan for downloadable content (DLC) or sequels if your game is successful.
- **Continue Marketing:** Keep promoting your game and engaging your community.

Summary & Takeaways

Your Roadmap to Success

- Balance market awareness with your creative vision to find your unique niche.
- Document everything meticulously to stay on track.
- Choose your tools wisely—an existing engine is best for a first project.
- Prioritize a simple, fun prototype before building the full game.
- Embrace the different phases of development (Alpha, Beta, Release) for a polished product.
- A successful launch is not the end, but the beginning of a relationship with your players.

Questions and Answers

- Thank you for your time.
- Open floor for questions.